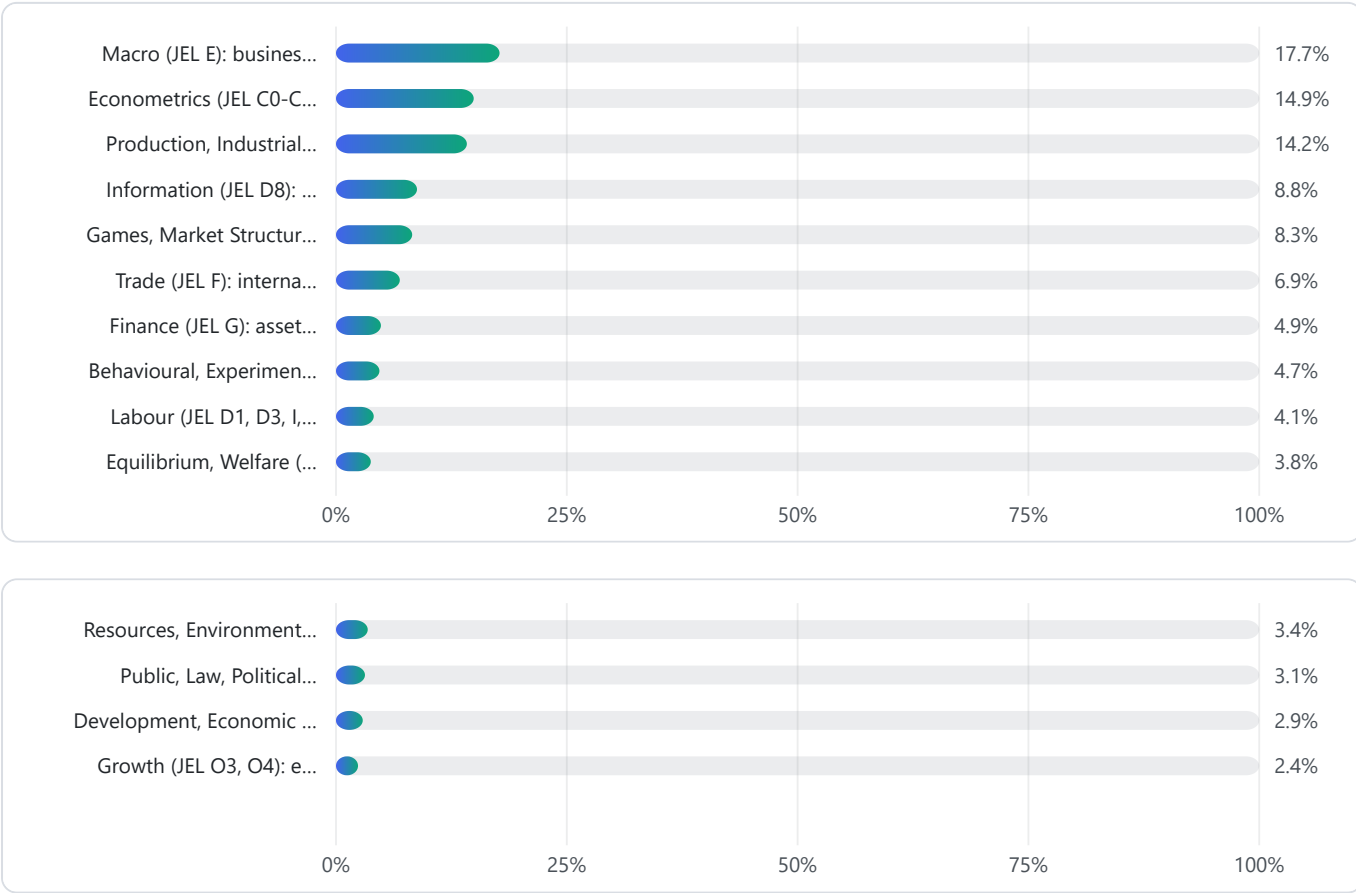




Which field of economics will the 2026 Nobel Prize in Economic Sciences recognize?

Generated 2026년 10월 10일 오후 1:24

Forecast distribution



Full option labels

1. Macro (JEL E): business cycles, money and monetary policy, consumption and saving, fiscal policy, national accounts
2. Econometrics (JEL Co-C5, C8): econometric theory and methods, causal inference, time series, data and estimation methods
3. Production, Industrial Organization (JEL D2, L, M): theory of the firm, transaction costs and organizations, industrial organization and regulation, business economics
4. Information (JEL D8): asymmetric information, contract theory, mechanism design, decision making under uncertainty
5. Games, Market Structure (JEL C7, D4): game theory, bargaining, matching, auctions and market design
6. Trade (JEL F): international trade, international finance and open-economy macroeconomics, exchange rates

7. Finance (JEL G): asset pricing, corporate finance, banking and financial crises, financial markets
8. Behavioural, Experimental (JEL C9, D9): behavioural economics, psychological and intertemporal decision making, laboratory and field experiments
9. Labour (JEL D1, D3, I, J): labour markets, household and family economics, income distribution, health and education economics
10. Equilibrium, Welfare (JEL C6, D5, D6): general equilibrium, welfare economics, social choice, mathematical and optimization methods
11. Resources, Environment (JEL Q, R): environmental and climate economics, natural resources and energy, agriculture, urban and regional economics
12. Public, Law, Political Economy (JEL D7, H, K, P): public economics and taxation, collective decision making and public choice, law and economics, political economy and economic systems
13. Development, Economic History (JEL N, O1, O2, O5): development economics, poverty, economic history, economywide country studies
14. Growth (JEL O3, O4): economic growth, innovation and technological change, productivity, institutions and growth

TL;DR

Macro leads my forecast at 18%, followed by Econometrics at 15% and Production/Industrial Organization at 14% (calculation). Together, these three fields hold 47% of the probability (calculation). The decisive distinction is the contribution named in the official motivation, not the laureate's usual specialty.

Context

The announcement remains ahead of the client's request. The Academy has scheduled it for October 12, 2026, at 11:45 CEST at the earliest, equivalent to 09:45 UTC (Academy announcement, published February 2). Historical prizes inform this forecast; they do not resolve it.

There is no authenticated public shortlist. Nominations and evaluations remain confidential for fifty years (Academy selection process). The forecast therefore combines historical recognition patterns with evidence about mature contributions, then allows for uncertainty about their primary JEL classification.

Evidence

The historical sample contains 57 annual prizes and 99 laureates, covering 1969–2025. The relevant observation unit is the annual prize, not the individual laureate (official prize history). I

reconstructed the full annual history below from the official motivations. These are forecasting labels, not a verified copy of the resolver’s three-model consensus.

Field	Complete central reconstruction: prize years	Averaged historical count used
Econometrics	1969, 1980, 1989, 2000, 2003	5.5
Equilibrium/Welfare	1970, 1972, 1973, 1975, 1983, 1988, 1998	7.0
Games/Market Structure	1994, 2005, 2012, 2020	4.0
Behavioural/Experimental	2002, 2017	2.0
Labour	1992, 2010, 2015, 2021, 2023	4.5
Production/IO	1978, 1982, 1991, 2014	4.5
Public/Law/Political Economy	1986	1.0
Information	1996, 2001, 2007, 2016	4.5
Macro	1974, 1976, 1984, 1985, 1995, 2004, 2006, 2011	7.5
Trade	1977, 1999, 2008	3.0
Finance	1981, 1990, 1997, 2013, 2022	5.5
Development/Economic History	1979, 1993, 2019	3.0
Growth	1971, 1987, 2024, 2025	4.0
Resources/Environment	2009, 2018	1.0

The fractional counts average two interpretations, with equal weight, for five awards: saving versus finance in 1985; resources versus organizational economics in 2009; labour versus information/search in 2010; macro versus econometric methods in 2011; and climate/resource economics versus macro in 2018. This reduces dependence on debatable historical labels.

Historical rotation receives limited weight. Dolton and Tol report semi-regular rotation, but their published field counts describe laureates, while this question requires one outcome per ceremony. Their transition model also spans fourteen fields against only fifty-six annual transitions. That is a sparse foundation for a strong claim that one field is due next (March 21, 2026 preprint). I do not use its transition table as a calibrated probability distribution.

Precursor awards identify mature work better than imminent winners. My cross-match of all sixteen economics Nemmers recipients from 1994–2024 finds ten Nobel recipients through 2025, but only two who won in the same calendar year. Among those ten, the median calendar-year lag was seven years. These are person-level counts, measured through the last completed Nobel award; eventual conversion remains censored for recipients who have not yet won

(Nemmers recipient history; Nobel recipient history). This restrains the weight placed on fresh recognition.

Macro has the clearest current contribution package. Woodford's Nemmers recognition concerns New Keynesian fluctuations and monetary-policy theory and practice (2024 announcement). The BBVA award announced on February 25, 2025 recognized Blanchard, Galí and Woodford for modern macroeconomics and monetary and fiscal policy rules (BBVA release). Clarivate then recognized Woodford's monetary-policy contribution on September 17, 2026 (Clarivate release). These recognitions overlap. I treat them as evidence of one mature body of work, not independent committee endorsements.

Empirical industrial organization supplies another strong route, but its classification is less stable. The BBVA recognition announced in February 2018 emphasized Bresnahan, Pakes and Porter's methods for measuring market power and studying industry behaviour (official release). Pakes's Nemmers citation likewise emphasizes empirical IO, mergers, prices and productivity (2022 recognition). By contrast, the BLP recognition concerns a demand-estimation method introduced in their 1995 paper (Yale's September 23, 2020 account). I separate a broad industry-analysis prize from a narrow estimation-method prize rather than counting both as automatic IO outcomes.

Econometrics also has independent support. Newey's current Nemmers citation identifies semiparametric econometrics, variance estimation and foundations for machine-learning inference; the page is undated, so I use the verified award year without assigning an announcement day (2026 award page). Manski's award, announced February 25, 2026, concerns uncertainty, inference and policy evaluation with incomplete evidence (BBVA release). Policy applications do not turn these methodological contributions into Public economics.

Other mature contributions keep the distribution broad. The recognition records include Rubinstein and Kreps in game and decision theory, and Helpman in international economics (Nemmers history). Grossman's information-economics contribution is documented in his Clark Medal citation (AEA citation). Natural capital and political economy have distinct routes through Dasgupta and Besley–Persson–Tabellini (environmental-economics recognition; political-economy recognition).

The symposium evidence adds a weak Trade signal. The Academy lists exchange rates and international capital markets for 2026, followed by international trade for 2027. I could not verify the first meeting's dates or participants, so its listing does not establish a shortlist or a same-year award connection (official symposium programme). The committee roster establishes who evaluates candidates, not which field they intend to select (official roster).

My numerical model gives the historical component one-quarter of the weight and the contribution component three-quarters. For field f , let n_f be the averaged count above. Add

one to each count, multiply Growth by 0.4, and normalize. This gives h_f . The Growth multiplier is my judgment about overlapping recent recognition, not a committee rule. The contribution distribution q_f comes from the following mutually exclusive scenarios. Their weights and conditional classifications are my assumptions, not measured nomination frequencies; the supporting recognition records are linked above.

Dominant recognized contribution	Scenario weight	Conditional field allocation
Monetary economics/stabilization	20%	Macro 95%; Finance 5%
Broad empirical IO	11%	IO 65%; Econometrics 25%; Games 10%
BLP demand-estimation methods	8%	Econometrics 60%; IO 35%; Games 5%
Digital markets/organizations	9%	IO 65%; Games 15%; Information 10%; Econometrics 5%; Growth 5%
Core econometric inference	9%	Econometrics 90%; Information 10%
Dynamic games/bargaining	6%	Games 85%; Information 10%; Behavioural 5%
Financial information/contracts	4%	Information 75%; Finance 15%; IO 10%
Networks	4%	Information 85%; Games 15%
International economics	8%	Trade 90%; Growth 5%; Public 5%
Behavioural economics/experiments	5%	Behavioural 90%; Labour 8%; Information 2%
Labour/household economics	3%	Labour 75%; Econometrics 20%; Public 5%
Political/public economics	3%	Public 85%; Growth 10%; Macro 5%
Resources/natural capital	4%	Resources 90%; Equilibrium 5%; Development 5%
Other finance	2%	Finance 85%; Macro 10%; Information 5%
Equilibrium/welfare	1%	Equilibrium 90%; Public 10%
Development/economic history	2%	Development 85%; Growth 10%; Labour 5%
Other growth	1%	Growth 85%; Macro 10%; Trade 5%

The final calculation is $p_f = 0.25h_f + 0.75q_f$. The scenario weights sum to one hundred percent, and each conditional allocation sums to one hundred percent. I use no betting prices, polls or public forecast aggregates in this calculation.

What's non-obvious

A strong empirical-IO candidate pool does not translate directly into an IO outcome. An award for estimating demand resembles the method-centred recognition of Heckman and McFadden; an award for understanding competition resembles Tirole's problem-centred recognition (official historical motivations). The same distinction applies to digital economics. Clarivate's Athey–Varian recognition concerns information technology, not automatically asymmetric information (2026 citation). Networks can fall under D85/Information, auctions under D44/Games, and international monetary economics under F/Trade (AEA classification).

A strict annual field label also hides recent recognition of neighbouring contributions. Econometrics was substantively recognized in 2021 even though this question's equal-contribution-share, first-named rule points to Labour: Card's labour contribution and Angrist–Imbens's causal-method contribution each received half the prize (official announcement). Likewise, the recent institutions and innovation prizes map to Growth under the supplied conventions, while covering work adjacent to political economy and economic history (official motivations). I discount overlap in recognized ideas, not just repetition of labels.

Uncertainties

The largest missing information is the committee's actual contribution shortlist and expert assessments. Those would distinguish mature work that is under active consideration from mature work that remains outside the final selection (confidential selection process). Public precursor awards cannot close that gap.

I also could not verify the resolver's exact historical consensus labels, model versions or prompts. My reconstruction is explicit, but other borderline prizes remain debatable. The eventual motivation and any split-contribution structure can move probability between fields without changing the winning economists.

In my model, varying the historical weight from 15% to 40.0%, the narrow BLP Econometrics allocation from 40.0% to 80%, and the monetary scenario's relative weight produces sensitivity ranges of 15–21% for Macro, 13–18% for Econometrics and 12–17% for IO (model inputs). These are modelling ranges, not statistical confidence intervals. The final distribution is conditional on a valid classification into the listed options; its decimal places preserve the arithmetic, not equivalent precision about the committee's decision.

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Question Details

The 2026 Sveriges Riksbank Prize in Economic Sciences in Memory of Alfred Nobel is scheduled to be announced on Monday 12 October 2026, 11:45 CEST at the earliest. The options are the 14 fields of economics of Dolton and Tol (2026), each defined as a group of JEL codes (in brackets) and illustrated by a few keywords. The field of the awarded contribution is read from the official motivation through its JEL code; exactly one option resolves.

Resolution Criteria

Resolves to the field that contains the primary JEL code of the contribution recognized by the official motivation of the 2026 prize (nobelprize.org). The primary code is the level-3 JEL code of the core of the recognized contribution, determined by the same procedure that coded the prizes of 1969-2025: three language models code the official motivation independently, and their consensus (JEL letter, then two-digit field, then code; a two-model majority, otherwise the highest score) is mapped to the fields by the code groups in the option labels. If the prize is divided between contributions in different fields, the overall motivation of the prize is coded when the announcement gives one; otherwise the contribution with the larger share counts; if the shares are equal, the contribution named first in the announcement counts. If the primary code is in no option (JEL A, B, Y, Z or a general code such as Do), the field named by the majority of the contribution's secondary codes counts; if no field can be assigned, the question is annulled.